distribution of the fifty-two shakti-peeths [10] (i.e. pilgrimage sites related to this tradition) came to be spread across the subcontinent—from Kamakhya in Assam to Hinglaj in Baluchistan, and from Jwalamukhi in Himachal Pradesh to Jaffna in Sri Lanka. There are even Shakti temples in South East Asia. The ninth-century Prambanan temple complex in central Java, Indonesia, has a shrine dedicated to the Goddess Durga slaying the demon Mahishasura. The exquisitely carved idol would not look out of place, twelve centuries later, at the annual Durga Puja festival in modern Kolkata.

THE TURKIC INVASIONS

In many ways, life in the subcontinent till the beginning of the eleventh century remained more or less a continuation of earlier times. Maritime trade continued to flourish in the southern ports even as foreign scholars continued to flock to Nalanda to study. There had been changes in architecture, technology and style, but the cities of the subcontinent would have been broadly familiar to a visitor from a thousand years earlier. However, the country was about to experience a major shift.

In the late tenth century, waves of Turkic invasions began to erode the Hindu–Buddhist kingdoms of Afghanistan. In 963 AD, the Turks captured the strategically important town of Ghazni. From there they steadily ate away at the Hindu Shahi kingdom of Kabul and pushed them into Punjab. The Shahis doggedly fought back for decades but, on 27 November 1001, they were routed by Mahmud of Ghazni in a battle near Peshawar. The Shahi king Jayapala was so distraught that he abdicated in favour of his son and committed suicide by climbing on to his own funeral pyre. [11] The Shahis would continue to fight the Turks, but they were now a spent force.

Over the next quarter-century, Mahmud would make seventeen raids into India, many of them directed at wealthy temple towns such as Mathura and Nagarkot. His most infamous raid was against the temple of Somnath, Gujarat, in 1026 AD. It is said that this single attack left over fifty thousand of its defenders dead and yielded twenty million dirhams worth of gold, silver and gems. Although the Somnath temple would be destroyed and